

EUROPEAN INFANTRY ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

Peacetime armies hardly existed prior to the 16th century: professional troops were either bodyguards or employed for garrison duties. However, during wartime troops were recruited and mercenaries hired. Permanent infantry units, such as the Spanish *tercio* (see p.117), were established in the early 16th century. They were drilled in battlefield tactics and trained in the effective use of their weapons. Such forces, together with the increased availability of handguns, challenged the supremacy of the fully armoured knights. Manufacturers in Italy, Germany, and the Low Countries increased their production of swords, staff weapons, handguns, and armour, transporting them all over Europe to equip these new military units.

► HALBERD

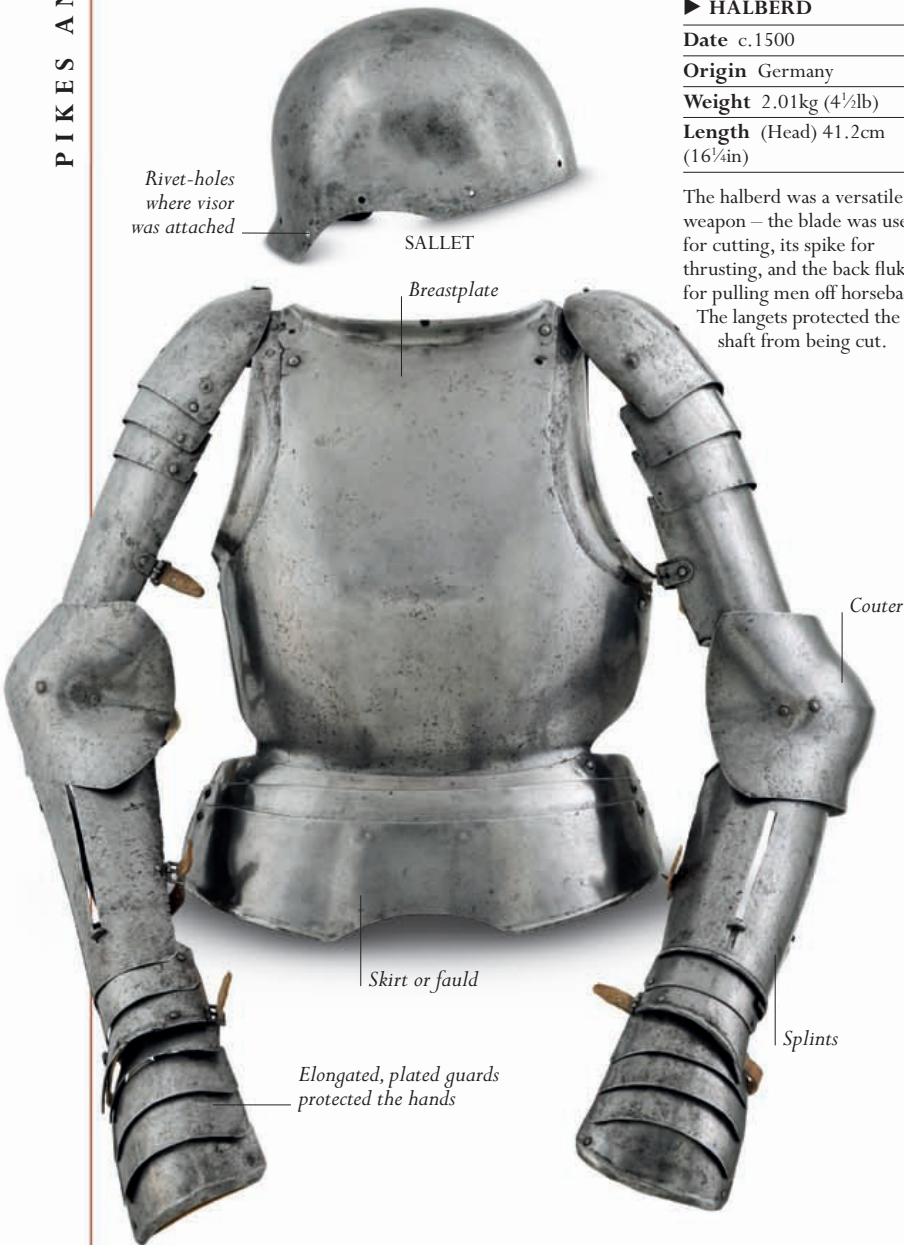
Date c.1500

Origin Germany

Weight 2.01kg (4½lb)

Length (Head) 41.2cm (16¼in)

The halberd was a versatile weapon – the blade was used for cutting, its spike for thrusting, and the back fluke for pulling men off horseback. The langets protected the shaft from being cut.



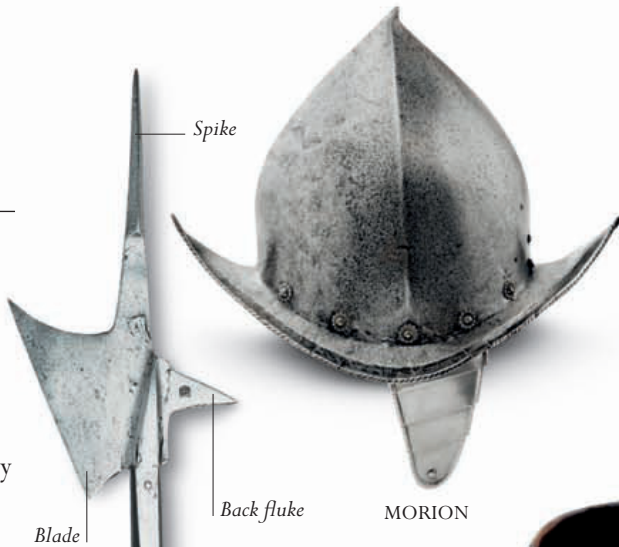
▲ ALMAIN RIVET (MUNITION ARMOUR)

Date c.1520

Origin Italy

Material Iron, leather

In 1512, King Henry VIII ordered 2,000 of these simple armours from a merchant in Florence. The arm defences, called “splints”, consisted of gutter-shaped plates attached to a dished couter over the elbow. The plates and the couter were joined by leather on the inside. Instead of gauntlets, a series of laminations covered the hands.



▼ SPANISH TERCIO ARMOUR

Date c.1570

Origin Italy

Material Iron, leather

Italy, and especially Milan, made munition armour of this type in large quantities. This cuirass was worn with full arms and an open helmet such as the morion shown. The *tercios* were armed with a pike or gun and a sword.

